within the SED. ‘Ulbricht will disappear as soon as Khrushchev deems it appropriate within the framework of lessening international tensions which he also desires,’ the paper concluded.12

As it happened, Erich Honecker was assured enough to spend the summer of 1963 out of the limelight. He withheld comment on US President John F. Kennedy’s tour of Berlin and Konrad Adenauer’s resignation. However, he did make a series of speeches before the Volkskammer elections on 20 October which, predictably saw 99.25 per cent participation and 99.9 per cent ‘yes’ votes for the SED-backed unified list – an indication that reforms did not spill over into the democratic process.

During those long hot summer months, Honecker had been involved in drafting a new ‘border pass agreement’, which when implemented, allowed West Berliners to visit relatives in the GDR during Christmas 1963. The scheme led to more than 700,000 people taking advantage of this chance to see their loved ones – in all, 1.2 million people crossed over to the East between 19 December and 5 January and generated some much-needed welcome press in the West.13 It was at this time that the MfS took over passport control at border crossings to the FRG, West Berlin, Poland and Czechoslovakia. In a country that only allowed its citizens to travel abroad under exceptional circumstances, controls over who travels where and when, was of strategic importance.

At the beginning of 1964, the focus of Erich Honecker’s activity seems to have been in the economic area and on the defence front, where he helped to establish ‘construction soldier’ units which gave conscientious objectors the option of serving ‘with a spade’ instead of a gun. His work diary shows he was present at the opening of several of Ulbricht’s prestige building projects, including the new State Council headquarters on Berlin’s Marx-Engels-Platz and the House of Teachers on Alexanderplatz.

During May, he was with Ulbricht in Budapest, where, to everyone’s surprise, the GDR failed to reverse Hungary’s decision to exchange trade missions with Bonn. Hungarian leader Janos Kadar explained, ‘My government seeks good relationships and mutually advantageous contact with the capitalist States.’ A month later, Honecker accompanied Ulbricht to Moscow for the signing of a treaty of cooperation and mutual assistance